

The ACT versus the SAT: A History

Origins, Rivalry, Redesigns, and the Evidence on Two American Admissions Tests

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Executive Snapshot

Two tests have defined American college admissions for most of a century. The SAT, born in 1926, grew out of Army intelligence testing and was sold as a measure of innate scholastic aptitude. The ACT, launched in 1959, was built as a deliberate rival: a curriculum-based achievement test for the public-university heartland. For decades they split the country geographically, the SAT on the coasts and the ACT in the middle and the South.

The ACT briefly overtook the SAT in test-takers in 2012, the SAT reclaimed the lead in 2018, and both then collapsed in volume during the pandemic. The same period saw the tests redesigned (a fully digital adaptive SAT in 2024, a shorter ACT with optional science in 2025), challenged by a sweeping test-optional movement, and then partly vindicated when MIT, Dartmouth, Yale, Brown, and Harvard reinstated testing requirements in 2022 to 2024, citing research that scores predict college performance and can help, not hurt, disadvantaged applicants.

This report traces both tests from origin to the present, compares their formats and evidence base, and weighs the criticisms honestly. Where the evidence is strong and replicated, it says so; where claims are correlational, stakeholder-funded, or contested, it flags them.

1. Definition and Background

What the two tests are

The SAT and the ACT are standardized tests used in United States undergraduate admissions. Both are taken mainly by high school juniors and seniors, both are multiple-choice (with periods of an optional essay), and both produce a single headline score that colleges use to compare applicants from different schools on a common scale.

- SAT: owned by the College Board, a nonprofit membership association of colleges and schools founded in 1900. Scored today on a 400 to 1600 scale across two sections, Evidence-Based Reading and Writing, and Math.
- ACT: originally "American College Testing," developed at the University of Iowa. Scored on a 1 to 36 composite, historically the average of four sections (English, Math, Reading, Science).

The framing that started the rivalry: aptitude versus achievement

The conceptual difference at the heart of the rivalry is old and largely a matter of original design intent. The SAT was conceived as an aptitude test, meant to measure reasoning ability thought to be relatively independent of any particular curriculum. The ACT was conceived as an achievement test, meant to measure what a student had actually learned in the standard college-preparatory curriculum (BestColleges, 2022, "A Brief History of the ACT").

That distinction has softened in practice. The two tests correlate heavily, both have moved toward curriculum-relevant content, and the SAT's own name changes track its retreat from the "aptitude" claim (see Section 2). Treat the aptitude-versus-achievement split as accurate to how the tests were born, not as a clean description of how differently they function today.

The eugenics origins of admissions testing

Honest history requires naming where the SAT came from. During World War I, psychologist Robert Yerkes chaired the Army's mental-testing program, producing the Army Alpha (for literate recruits) and Army Beta (for illiterate or non-English-speaking recruits) group tests. Carl Brigham, a Princeton psychologist, administered these tests and in 1923 reanalyzed the Army data in "A Study of American Intelligence" (Princeton University Press), asserting a racial hierarchy with "Nordic" stock at the top and arguing immigration "should not only be restrictive but highly selective" (Brigham, 1923).

Brigham built the first SAT for the College Board in 1926. Two correctives matter for an accurate account:

- Brigham publicly recanted. In "Intelligence Tests of Immigrant Groups" (Psychological Review, 1930), he repudiated his 1923 work, writing that "one of the most pretentious of these comparative racial studies, the writer's own, was without foundation" and acknowledging the tests had confounded innate ability with English fluency, schooling, and culture. Accounts that cite the 1923 racism but omit the 1930 reversal tell only half the story.
- Brigham did not found ETS, a claim that circulates widely. Educational Testing Service was created in 1947, four years after Brigham's death, by merging the testing arms of the College Board, the Carnegie Foundation, and the American Council on Education. Brigham actually opposed creating a single dominant testing agency (David Owen, "Inventing the SAT").

The lineage (Yerkes' Army tests, 1917; Brigham's racial reanalysis, 1923; the SAT, 1926) is documented. The popular claim that Brigham's book directly caused the 1924 Immigration Act overstates a more diffuse influence; Harry Laughlin's congressional testimony and Yerkes' data were the more direct inputs (EBSCO Research Starters; Undark, "Born of Eugenics").

2. The SAT: Origins and Evolution

From 1901 exams to the 1926 SAT

The College Board administered its first essay-based subject exams in June 1901 to 973 students. The multiple-choice SAT ("Scholastic Aptitude Test") was first given on June 23, 1926, to roughly 8,000 students, with 315 questions in 97 minutes (Wikipedia, "History of the SAT").

A test that kept changing its name

The SAT's naming history is a slow-motion retreat from the word "aptitude":

- 1926 to 1990: "Scholastic Aptitude Test."
- ~1990: a College Board commission concluded the test "could no longer be accurately described as a test of aptitude," intending to correct the impression that it measured "something that is innate and impervious to change."
- 1993: renamed "Scholastic Assessment Test"; the "SAT I: Reasoning Test" and "SAT II: Subject Tests" labels appear.
- 1997: the College Board declared that "SAT" is just a brand name and no longer stands for anything (PrepScholar, "What Does SAT Stand For?").

Major format and scoring redesigns

- 1930: split into separate verbal and math sections, a structure that lasted until 2005.
- 1941 to 1942: the familiar 200 to 800 score scale was fixed against a 1941 reference group of about 10,000 students; this scale stayed in use until 1995.
- 1994: antonyms removed, more passage-based reading, calculators permitted for the first time, and grid-in math questions added.
- 2005: the "New SAT" added a Writing section with a required essay, pushing the top score to 2400; analogies were dropped. University of California criticism that the test did not match high-school curricula was a driver.
- 2016: returned to the 1600 scale (Evidence-Based Reading and Writing, plus Math); the essay became optional; the quarter-point "guessing penalty" was eliminated, so there is now no penalty for wrong answers. Led by College Board president David Coleman.
- 2021: SAT Subject Tests and the optional essay discontinued.
- 2024: the fully digital, adaptive SAT launched in the United States on March 9, 2024 (international rollout began 2023).

The digital, adaptive SAT

The current SAT is taken on the College Board's Bluebook app and runs about 2 hours 14 minutes (down from roughly 3 hours), with about 98 questions across two sections. Each section is split into two timed modules, and the test is multistage adaptive: performance on the first module determines whether the second is harder or easier, which affects the achievable score (College Board; Test Innovators).

The 1995 recentering

By the 1990s the 1941-anchored scale had drifted; average verbal performance had sat near 430 for a generation, and the scale had distortions (a single omission could cost 30 to 40 points). Starting with the April 1995 administration, the College Board "recentered" the scale to restore the mean to near 500, using a class-of-1990 reference group of about one million students. A typical student gained roughly 80 points on verbal and 20 on math (ERIC ED563023).

Important nuance: this was a rescaling, not an easier test. Percentile rank among test-takers was unchanged, so the popular "dumbing down" framing is, technically, a misconception, though the change was genuinely controversial and critics argued it masked decades of score decline. Treat "dumbing down" as a contested interpretation, not a fact.

Governance: College Board and ETS

The College Board owns the SAT. Educational Testing Service, chartered in 1947, historically developed and administered the test under contract while the College Board retained ownership. In the digital era the division of labor has shifted (the College Board has brought more work in-house, and ETS went through significant layoffs in 2023); the exact present-day arrangement is not fully public.

3. The ACT: Origins and Evolution

A rival built on purpose (1959)

The ACT was first administered on November 7, 1959, to 75,406 students. Its architect was Everett Franklin Lindquist, a University of Iowa education professor who had worked on standardized testing since the 1920s and helped invent the optical mark-reading scanner that made mass scoring feasible. He partnered with University of Iowa registrar Ted McCarrel and founded ACT, Inc. in Iowa City (Wikipedia, "Everett Franklin Lindquist"; ACT Leadership Blog, 2019).

Lindquist objected to the SAT's aptitude framing and built the ACT as a curriculum-based achievement test, a direct challenge to the test then literally named for "aptitude." This origin tied the ACT to public state-university systems rather than the selective Northeastern institutions that favored the SAT.

Sections, scoring, and how the composite works

- 1959: four 45-minute tests, English, Mathematics, Social Studies, and Natural Sciences.
- 1989 "Enhanced ACT": Social Studies became Reading; Natural Sciences became Science Reasoning, shifting from recall to data interpretation. Section and composite means were scaled to 18.
- Scoring: each section is 1 to 36 with no penalty for wrong answers; the composite is the rounded average of the sections.

Major changes over time

- 2005: an optional Writing (essay) test added, scored 2 to 12.
- 2015: the essay was reformatted and lengthened from 30 to 40 minutes; after a brief, troubled move to a 1 to 36 essay scale, ACT reverted to 2 to 12 over reliability problems.
- 2020: ACT began calculating and reporting superscores (best section scores across test dates), though each college decides whether to use them.
- 2025 "Enhanced ACT": the big restructuring. The core test shrank from 215 to 171 questions and from roughly 3 hours to about 2; the core composite (about 125 minutes) now reflects only English, Math, and Reading.

The 2025 redesign: optional science and a shorter test

The headline 2025 change is that the Science section became optional and was removed from the composite; when taken, it is reported as a separate 1 to 36 score. Math answer choices dropped from five to four. National online testing on the enhanced format began in April 2025, extending to all national Saturday testing by September 2025. Unlike the digital SAT, the ACT remains linear, not computer-adaptive, and both paper and digital formats are still offered (U.S. News; Learner.com).

From nonprofit to private equity (2024)

After about 65 years as an Iowa nonprofit, ACT announced in April 2024 a partnership with Nexus Capital Management, a Los Angeles private-equity firm, transitioning the testing business to a for-profit public benefit corporation (the deal closed in May 2024). The new entity, ACT Education Corp., combines ACT with its data subsidiary Encoura; a continuing Iowa nonprofit retains an equity stake and a research mission. Janet Godwin stayed on as CEO (ACT Industry Insights, 2024; Inside Higher Ed, 2024).

Observers, including the College Board's letter to its membership, raised transparency and accountability concerns about a college gatekeeper owned by private equity. The "public benefit corporation" label is a legal mission commitment, not a return to nonprofit status. The long-term effects on pricing and strategy are commentary, not settled fact.

4. Head to Head: How the Two Tests Compare

Format and content

Feature	SAT (2024 digital)	ACT (2025 enhanced)
Score scale	400 to 1600 (two sections)	1 to 36 composite (3 core sections)
Science section	None (never had one)	Optional, separate score, not in composite
Format	Digital, multistage adaptive	Linear; paper and digital both offered
Length	~2 hr 14 min, ~98 questions	~2 hr core (125 min), ~131 core questions

Calculator	Allowed on all math (Desmos built in)	Allowed on entire Math section
Pacing	~1 min 22 sec per question	~57 sec per question (faster)
Wrong-answer penalty	None (since 2016)	None

The ACT is the faster-paced test; the SAT gives more time per question. The most visible content difference is the science section, and even that narrowed in 2025 when the ACT made science optional. Calculator and no-penalty policies have largely converged.

Concordance: putting 1600 and 36 on one scale

Colleges compare scores across the two tests using an official concordance, most recently the 2018 ACT and College Board concordance built from about 600,000 students in the class of 2017 who took both. The tables match scores at equal percentile rank ("concordant," not "equal"). Sample anchors: ACT 36 maps to SAT 1590; 34 to 1500; 30 to 1370; 25 to 1210; 20 to 1040.

A real caveat: both tests have been redesigned since 2018 (digital SAT in 2024, enhanced ACT in 2025), so the only official concordance now predates the current forms, and no updated official table exists as of 2026.

The geography of the rivalry

For decades the SAT dominated the Northeast, Mid-Atlantic, and West Coast, while the ACT dominated the Midwest, Rocky Mountains, and South. The split traces to origins: the SAT's prestige was tied to selective Northeastern institutions (Harvard refused to consider ACT scores until the 1990s), while Lindquist's curriculum-aligned ACT fit broad-access public university systems. That map is now heavily scrambled by state testing contracts (see Section 6); Tennessee, for example, requires all 11th graders to take the SAT or ACT, with the choice left to the district.

5. The Competition for Test-Takers

The 2012 crossover and the back-and-forth since

In 2012 the ACT surpassed the SAT in total test-takers for the first time, by a razor-thin margin: 1,666,017 ACT versus 1,664,479 SAT, a gap of about 1,500 students. The ACT led from 2012 to 2017; the SAT reclaimed the top spot in 2018, driven largely by state-funded SAT School Day contracts. Both tests then fell sharply after 2019 as the pandemic closed test centers.

Graduating class	ACT	SAT
2012	1,666,017	1,664,479
2016	~2.09M	~1.64M
2018	~1.9M	~2.1M
2019	1.78M	~2.22M
2024	~1.4M	~1.97M
2025	~1.38M	~2.0M

Figures count unique students in a graduating cohort who took the test at least once, not administrations. A clean single-source series for 2013 to 2015, 2017, and 2020 to 2023 is not readily available; the authoritative primaries are the College Board's annual SAT Suite report and ACT's "Condition of College and Career Readiness." By 2025 both tests remained well below their 2019 peaks, with the SAT class of 2025 back above 2 million (its first time since 2020) and 97 percent testing digitally.

State-funded universal testing: the real driver

The single biggest force behind these swings is states paying for every junior to take one test in school, which instantly converts an entire class into test-takers for the winning vendor. The contract battles have been fierce:

- Colorado switched from the ACT to the SAT in a 2015 decision (a 5-year, \$12.4M College Board contract), first administered in 2017.
- Illinois switched ACT to SAT in 2015 (a 3-year, \$14.3M contract); ACT filed formal bid protests in 2016 and 2018 that did not succeed; then Illinois switched back to the ACT for the 2024 to 2025 school year.
- Michigan switched from the ACT to the SAT in 2015 (a 3-year, \$17M contract); ACT requested an appeal hearing.

The College Board's run of School Day wins in 2015 to 2017 is exactly why the SAT retook the volume lead in 2018, when its count jumped about 25 percent. Any state-by-state map is a time-stamped snapshot; the map is genuinely fluid (Illinois flipped twice in under a decade).

6. The Evidence: Do the Tests Predict Anything?

What the validity research shows

Across peer-reviewed and institutional studies, admissions test scores predict first-year college GPA, retention, and graduation at moderate-to-strong levels. High school GPA predicts about as well or slightly better; the test adds incremental value over GPA; and the SAT and ACT are roughly comparable. All of this is correlational, not causal.

Relationship	Coefficient	Source
SAT and first-year GPA (raw / range-corrected)	~.35 / ~.54	College Board; Mattern & Patterson 2014
SAT and freshman GPA (then controlling SES)	.47 (to .44)	Sackett et al. 2009
ACT and first-year GPA (meta-analysis)	~.51	Westrick et al. 2015
High school GPA and first-year GPA	~.58	Westrick et al. 2015
SAT incremental validity over HS GPA	~+.06	Mattern & Patterson 2014
UC variance explained: GPA / tests / both	~16% / ~21% / ~26%	UC STTF 2020

Two technical points make these numbers honest. First, range restriction: because colleges admit a higher-scoring slice of applicants, raw within-college correlations ($\sim .30$ to $.40$) understate the true relationship, which is why corrected coefficients run $\sim .47$ to $.54$. Second, Sackett et al. (2009, *Psychological Bulletin*) showed the test-grade link is not just a socioeconomic artifact: controlling for SES dropped the correlation only from $.47$ to $.44$, and the SAT added incremental validity over GPA in every dataset.

The University of California fight

The clearest illustration that evidence and policy can diverge is the University of California. Its faculty Standardized Testing Task Force (February 2020) found that, at UC, test scores predicted first-year GPA as well as or better than high school GPA, and that the test-score share of predictive power had risen from about 13 percent (2001) to about 20 percent (2015) as grade inflation eroded GPA's signal. The task force recommended keeping the tests.

Berkeley researchers Saul Geiser and (earlier) Geiser and Santelices argued the opposite, that high school GPA was the better and fairer predictor and that the task force's pro-test findings suffered from omitted-variable bias. In May 2020 the Regents voted, against their own faculty recommendation, to drop the tests; an August 2020 court injunction in *Smith v. Regents* then pushed UC to fully test-blind, and a 2021 settlement barred any UC campus from considering scores through spring 2025. UC adopted no replacement test.

The strongest pro-test pillar: Opportunity Insights

The most influential recent evidence comes from Raj Chetty's Opportunity Insights team. Friedman, Sacerdote, and Tine (January 2024) found that at Ivy-Plus colleges, controlling for demographics and even for the same high school's grades, a 1600 scorer earned a first-year college GPA about 0.43 points higher than a 1200 scorer, while a 4.0 high school GPA predicted less than 0.1 points over a 3.2. In other words, at these schools, the test out-predicts high school GPA, which has lost signal to grade inflation.

Crucially, conditional on score, students from less- and more-advantaged high schools earned "virtually identical" college GPAs, meaning the prediction did not bake in socioeconomic bias. The companion admissions study (Chetty, Deming, and Friedman, 2023) used a waitlist design to show, causally, that attending an Ivy-Plus college raises a student's odds of top-1% earnings and elite outcomes, and that academic credentials predicted success while legacy, athletic, and subjective ratings (which favor the wealthy) did not.

Caveats matter: these are Ivy-Plus samples, the GPA result is affected by range restriction (nearly all admits have near-4.0 GPAs), and "tests beat GPA" should not be generalized to less selective colleges. The admissions study is causal; the predictive-validity claims are correlational.

7. Criticisms and Limitations

The income and race score gaps

The strongest and most replicated criticism is that scores track family advantage. Using parental education as a clean public proxy, 2023 SAT means ran from 910 (no high school diploma) to 1181 (graduate degree), a roughly 271-point gradient (NCES Digest 2023, Table 226.10). Opportunity Insights found children of the top 1 percent are about 13 times more likely than low-income children to score 1300 or above; only about 2.5 percent of the bottom income quintile reaches 1300, and only about a quarter even take the test.

Score gaps by race are also large: 2023 SAT means were 1219 (Asian), 1082 (White), 943 (Hispanic/Latino), and 908 (Black). The central, genuinely unresolved debate is whether these gaps reflect upstream opportunity gaps (the view of most psychometricians and the Opportunity Insights authors, who call it "the accumulation of unequal opportunities over 18 years") or test bias. Validity studies generally find the tests predict about equally well across groups, which is the technical definition of unbiased; critics counter that predictive validity is circular because test and grades share the same upstream advantages.

Test prep: a real access gap, but modest effects

A common assumption is that wealthy families simply buy big scores through coaching. The best research says the effect is modest. Powers and Rock (1999) found about 26 combined SAT points from coaching; Briggs (2002, 2009) found similar; the NACAC review (Briggs, 2009) put average gains around 30 combined points (roughly 10 to 20 on math, 5 to 10 on reading) and noted that because a section's standard error is about 30 points, the average coaching effect "cannot be distinguished from measurement error."

Both things are true: the access gap in who can afford prep is real, and the measured payoff of prep is small. The income-score gap is driven far more by accumulated academic advantage than by the marginal points a prep course adds.

The FairTest critique and the test-optional surge

FairTest (the National Center for Fair and Open Testing, founded 1985) has long argued the tests are coachable, correlate with income and race, and add little beyond GPA. The test-optional movement it championed passed roughly 1,000 four-year colleges by the late 2010s, then exploded during COVID: by fall 2021, more than half of US four-year colleges were test-optional, and FairTest counted over 1,800 by fall 2022. Exact totals fluctuate and are cycle-specific.

Scandals

Two episodes dented public trust. The 2019 "Operation Varsity Blues" scandal included a test-fraud component: Rick Singer's network paid proctor Mark Riddell about \$10,000 per exam to secretly take or correct students' SAT and ACT tests at controlled test centers in California and Texas, often after manufacturing false learning-disability documentation to win extended time.

Felicity Huffman paid \$15,000 for her daughter's SAT to be corrected and served 14 days. (Lori Loughlin's \$500,000 case was the separate athletic-recruitment scheme, not test cheating.)

Separately, between 2013 and 2016 the College Board canceled or withheld SAT scores across Asia and the Middle East after recycled US test forms leaked. The May 2013 South Korea cancellation was the first time an entire country's administration was voided. A Reuters investigation found the College Board had at times administered exams it knew were compromised.

The adversity-score misfire

The College Board's attempt to contextualize scores shows how fraught the fixes are. Its Environmental Context Dashboard, piloted from 2017, rolled neighborhood and high-school factors (not family data, not race) into a single 1-to-100 "adversity score" shown to colleges but not students. After backlash in 2019, CEO David Coleman admitted "the single score was a mistake," and the College Board replaced it with "Landscape," which provides the underlying context data without a single verdict and shares it with students.

8. The Partial Reversal: Tests Come Back

After the test-optional peak, a cluster of selective schools reversed course, and their stated reasoning is the clearest "what changed" in the modern debate.

- MIT (March 2022) was first, saying it could not reliably predict student success without scores, that the math component mattered most, and that the test helped identify disadvantaged-but-prepared students who could study free on Khan Academy.
- Dartmouth (February 2024) became the first Ivy to reinstate, citing an internal study that scores read against same-high-school peers were especially good at surfacing high-achieving low-income, first-generation, and rural students, hundreds of whom were withholding strong scores under test-optional.
- Yale (February 2024) went "test-flexible" (scores required, but AP or IB accepted); Brown (March 2024) and Harvard (April 2024) reinstated outright, with Harvard citing Opportunity Insights research.

The cleanest policy finding behind the reversal: Sacerdote, Staiger, and Tine (2025, NBER) showed that high-achieving disadvantaged applicants (SAT above 1400) were more than three times as likely to be admitted if they submitted scores rather than withheld them (admission probability rising from 2.9 to 10.2 percent), because they systematically under-submitted scores that were strong in context. Test-optional did not increase applicant-pool diversity. Note: this "test-optional can hurt the disadvantaged" finding belongs to the Dartmouth and Opportunity Insights researchers; it is sometimes wrongly attributed to Brookings, whose best-known test piece argues the opposite.

An important scope limit: the strongest pro-test claims are specifically about Ivy-Plus and highly selective colleges. For the broad middle of US higher education, most of the roughly 1,800 test-optional institutions had not reverted, and test-optional remained the norm.

9. Bottom Line

The ACT and the SAT have spent 65 years as mirror-image rivals. The SAT came first, out of Army intelligence testing, carrying both a powerful brand and an uncomfortable eugenics-tinged origin that its creator himself later renounced. The ACT was engineered as the anti-SAT, a curriculum-based achievement test that won the heartland and, for a few years around 2012, the country. The supposed deep difference between them (aptitude versus achievement) was real at birth but has steadily eroded: the SAT dropped "aptitude" from its name, both tests went curriculum-relevant, the ACT made its signature science section optional in 2025, and the two are close enough that a single concordance table translates between them.

The competition between them is, more than anything, a competition for state contracts. The volume swings of the 2010s were not driven by students changing their minds but by states deciding which test every junior would take for free in school. That is worth remembering whenever someone declares one test "winning": the scoreboard mostly reflects procurement, not merit.

On the core question of whether the tests measure anything useful, the evidence is stronger than the test-optional era's rhetoric suggested. Scores predict college performance at moderate-to-strong levels, add information beyond an increasingly inflated high school GPA, and, when read in context, can surface talented students whom a grades-and-essays system overlooks. The Opportunity Insights work is the strongest pillar here, though it is concentrated at elite colleges and is mostly correlational. At the same time, the criticism that scores track wealth and race is equally well established. Both can be true: the test is a reasonably valid predictor and a mirror of upstream inequality. The prep-coaching panic, by contrast, is largely overblown; measured coaching effects are small.

The honest synthesis is that standardized tests are neither the meritocratic equalizer their defenders once claimed nor the useless instrument of privilege their critics describe. They are a modestly informative, contested signal whose fairness depends heavily on how admissions offices read it. The recent reinstatements at MIT, Dartmouth, and the Ivies suggest the most selective schools concluded that a contextualized score does more good than harm, especially for disadvantaged applicants who would otherwise have no way to stand out. Whether that logic holds for the rest of American higher education, where the test-optional experiment largely continues, is the open question the next decade will answer.

Questions that remain unanswered: whether the income and race gaps reflect opportunity or bias (a values dispute the data cannot fully settle); whether elite-college validity findings generalize downward; how private-equity ownership will reshape the ACT; and whether a redesigned, contextualized, digital test can be both predictive and equitable at scale.

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Note on evidence quality: Dates, format changes, scale histories, score gaps, the 2012 crossover, the 2024 Nexus transition, and the scandal facts are well documented. Predictive-validity findings favoring tests over GPA come largely from elite-college, correlational, and stakeholder-funded studies and should not be over-generalized. The aptitude-versus-achievement framing reflects original design intent, not how similarly the tests now function. State testing-requirement maps are time-stamped snapshots.